

Report Part Title: Hezbollah, the LAF and the Power of Perception

Report Title: The Lebanese Armed Forces, Hezbollah and the Race to Defeat ISIS

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Hezbollah, the LAF and the Power of Perception

Hezbollah's military action against JAN in Lebanon cannot be viewed along in a vacuum. Though based in Lebanon, Hezbollah has been an expeditionary force in Syria for at least the last six years, and Iran has leveraged the group's effectiveness in Iraq, Yemen and elsewhere. Both Hezbollah and Tehran are acutely aware of the mix of forces they must mitigate to sustain their "resistance" narrative across the Middle East.

To Iran and Hezbollah, the LAF must be capable enough to maintain stability, but preferably not to the point of demanding a monopoly on the use of violence in Lebanon. In Syria, Hezbollah and Iran prefer to maintain an expeditionary deployment with a toehold on the Golan Heights, but without the military and political costs of a high intensity proxy civil war. Some challenges are harder to mitigate. As the group deepens its asymmetric train and equip role in Yemen, it has no clear path to return to the broader Arab fold; a stark contrast from its status during and after the 2006 Israeli-Hezbollah conflict.

Possibly the most difficult challenges are the policy preferences of the U.S. and Russia in Syria. While diverging significantly, separately, both the U.S. and Russia have no preference that parts of Syria and its government become more closely integrated with Iran's "resistance" ideology, or its geopolitical preferences. Crucially, Russia's long-standing objective to transform the Syrian government and security apparatus in its own image clashes with Iran's preference of replicating the Hezbollah experience in Syria. As Syria's civil war becomes a less dynamic war of positions, Iran and their Hezbollah allies might increasingly find Syria – under Russian control to the west, and American preeminence to the east and south-east – to be increasingly inhospitable.

By taking preemptive military action against JAN, Hezbollah has taken the initiative away from the LAF and the Government of Lebanon. The operation began soon before Prime Minister Saad Hariri and other government officials were meant to travel to Washington. Meanwhile in Syria, JAN's main force took over much of Idlib province after forcing out Ahrar al-Sham – an Islamist group backed by Turkey. Furthermore, the day before Hezbollah's announcement, the Trump Administration confirmed that it was terminating a clandestine program to arm and train Syrian insurgents battling the Assad regime, including rebel groups in the Southern Front near the Syrian-Jordanian border.

The rationale for the timing of Hezbollah's attack against JAN is likely to be a source for persistent debate. Nonetheless, Hezbollah's actions are a source of embarrassment for both the Government and Lebanon's military. In the short to medium term, Hezbollah exhibited its usual flair for shaping the optics of its military campaign with significant emphasis on stagecraft and set pieces for public consumption. The militant group's media outlet released a daily stream of footage, along with maps showing the progression of Hezbollah forces conducting infantry maneuvers, how it utilized artillery, anti-aircraft guns and unguided rockets; Hezbollah also highlighted its combat engineering, showcasing its armored bulldozers as fighters captured abandoned JAN positions.

Initially, Hezbollah had hoped that the LAF would grant it permission to conduct operations from the west, immediately adjacent to the LAF's frontline with JAN. The LAF refused, forcing Hezbollah to adopt a less than optimal strategy focusing on pushing north from its southern positions in Lebanon and from the east in coordination with the Syrian Arab Army. Meanwhile, the LAF focused exclusively on maintaining its defensive posture, utilizing artillery and smaller caliber fire when JAN personnel appeared to be approaching 2nd Land Border Regiment positions, damaging its image and reputation at home and abroad.

Much has been made of purported coordination or cooperation between the LAF and Hezbollah, be it now in Aarsal or in past military engagements. According to LAF leadership and field commanders, when it comes to Hezbollah, the LAF continues to abide by a strict deconfliction policy that is not unlike how U.S. and Russian military forces deconflict in Syria. At no point did the Lebanese military command, units or smaller formations coordinate LAF actions with Hezbollah. Instead, the LAF leverages its intelligence branch to maintain channels as needed to every major faction in Lebanon.

Figure 2 and **Figure 4** show the rapid progression of Hezbollah forces as they took position after position from JAN forces. Between July 21, 2017 and July 24, 2017, Hezbollah had taken over more than 60% of territory previously held by JAN. **Figure 5** shows what remains of the area controlled by Nusra fighter before the declaration of a tentative ceasefire on July 27, 2017. Estimates of the number of dead, wounded and captured in combat vary widely. *Reuters* reported that more than 20 Hezbollah fighters and 150 JAN militants were killed in combat.

As was discussed earlier, one of the long-standing concerns of the LAF in any potential engagement with JAN and ISIS was the challenge of how to address the presence of a large, tented settlement of more than 11,000 Syrian refugees. By chipping away rapidly at the territory controlled by JAN, Hezbollah's military campaign has heightened the risk that JAN fighters and their families – and possibly ISIS members further north – may try to melt away into the refugee population near Wadi Hmeyyed. Lebanese intelligence services are actively tracking the possibility of joint JAN-ISIS attacks against LAF positions utilizing suicide truck bombs. Conveniently, Hezbollah will likely take credit if there are no such attacks, while conversely restating the importance of its military role should such attacks occur.

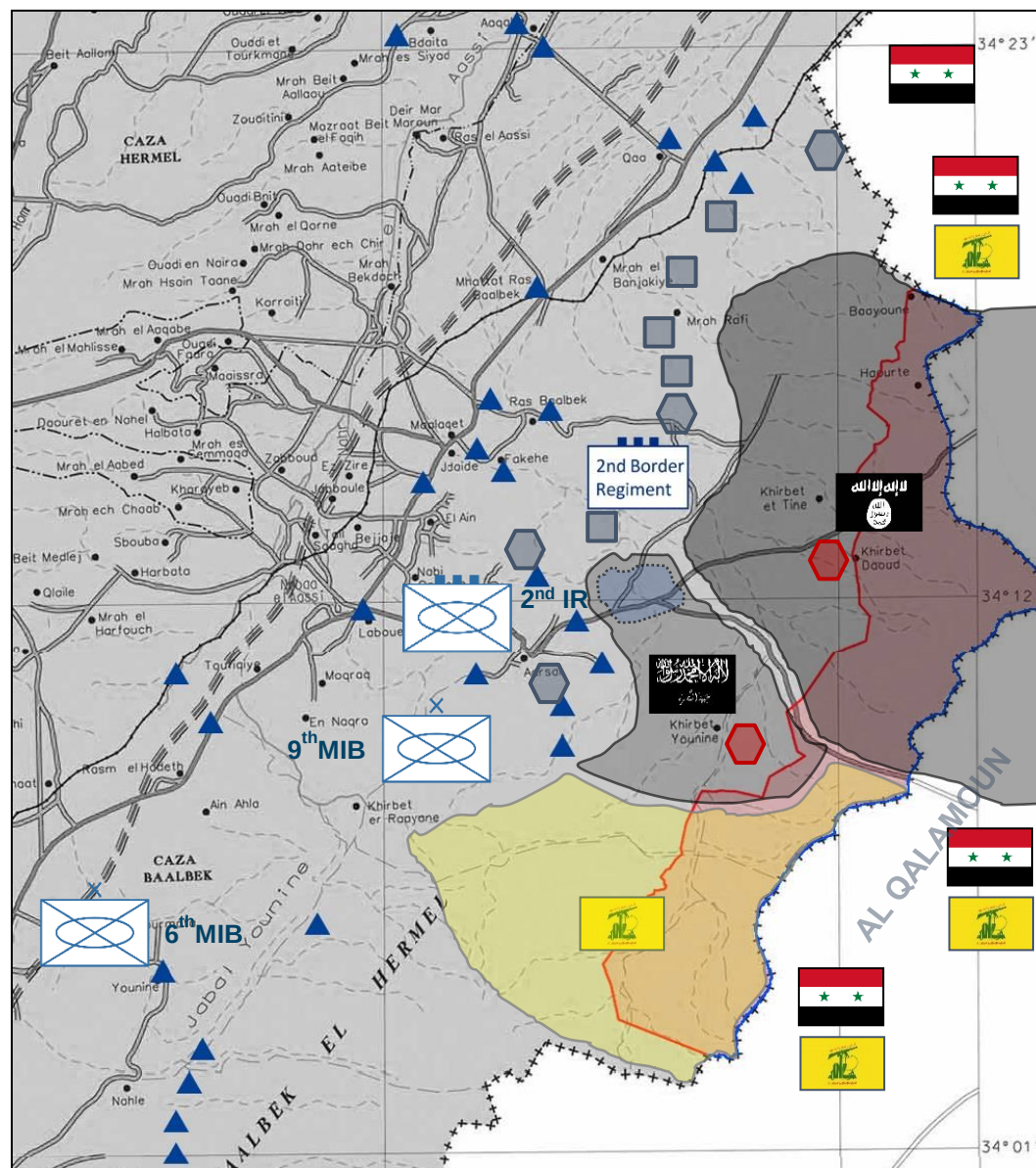
After a week of fighting, Hezbollah's most important victory is not defeating JAN. Before the ceasefire, JAN resistance grew markedly the closer Hezbollah fighters go to the tented settlement. Meanwhile, indiscriminate Syrian bombardment of the camps from Syrian side of the border threaten to undermine the narrative of a clean and swift campaign. Where Hezbollah truly succeeded is in shaping perception and the optics of itself, and by reciprocity effacing its long-term national security rival, the LAF. Hezbollah has little incentive to correct the perception that the LAF is either a non-player shaping the security politics of the Lebanese-Syrian frontier, or colluding with its fighters.

Hezbollah has a track record of shaping optics in ways that only serve to sow doubt about the LAF and its intentions. Hezbollah liberally plagiarizes footage of LAF guided missile strikes as its own. In late 2016, Hezbollah paraded U.S.-made M113s it had captured from the South Lebanon Army (SLA) – a one-time Israeli proxy in South Lebanon – in the process raising doubts about the LAF's exemplary end use monitoring track record. In April 2017, the presence of Hezbollah fighters near the headquarters of the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL) during a tour of the U.N. Blue Line separating Lebanon and Israel served to embarrass Government of Lebanon and LAF personnel on the ground.

One can critically point out that Hezbollah fighters on film appeared to have inferior levels of training and readiness relative to comparable LAF forces. One western military observer went so far as to compare some of what he saw to “second year cadets at a military academy,” but the content circulated for domestic and international consumption must not belie the fact that Hezbollah has proven to be a significant and well-disciplined asymmetric force.

What matters is that many Lebanese and many more watching around the world took away the impression that Hezbollah wanted: its military commanders and fighters executing a clear plan to evict JAN, while Lebanon's competing factions postured and debated without providing the Lebanese military with a clear mandate to act. And now that Hezbollah has all-but ensured JAN's demise and withdrawal from Lebanon, their continued presence in the greater Aarsal AOR threatens the pace and timing of planned LAF operations against ISIS. The LAF needs Hezbollah to honor a public pledge to turn over the areas it now controls over to the LAF. Failing to do so expeditiously undermines military planning efforts, delays the timing and pace of a potential LAF campaign, and gives ISIS more time to fortify its positions or close gaps in their own asymmetric defensive line.

Figure 4: The Lebanon-Syria Insecurity Nexus: Policing an Uncertain Border Region – July 24, 2017



● LAF Protected Border Observation Posts (PBOP) with Towers/ISR

■ LAF Forward Operating Base (FOB)

▲ LAF Checkpoint

■ Areas Controlled by the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria (ISIS)

■ Areas Controlled by Jabhat al-Nusra (JAN)

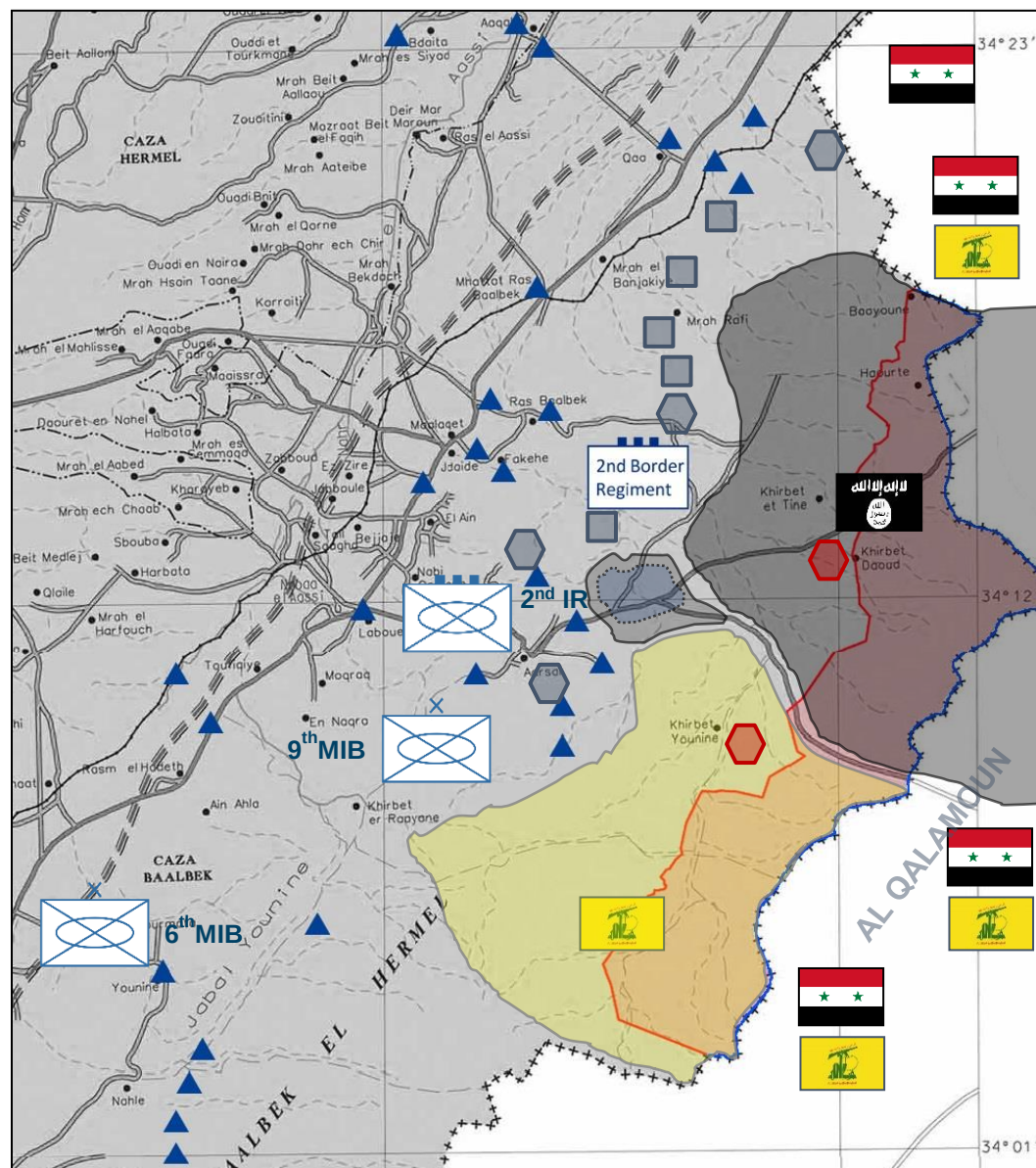
■ Areas Controlled by Hezbollah

■ Select Displaced Syrian Population

Note: Areas marked in red are areas contested by Syria. Red hexagons are LAF planned PBOP sites currently in the control areas of ISIS or JAN. "MIB" stands for Mechanized Infantry Brigade. "IR" stands for Intervention Regiment.

Source: Adapted by Aram Nerguizian from discussions with Lebanese Armed Forces and United Nations experts, July 27, 2017.

Figure 5: The Lebanon-Syria Insecurity Nexus: Policing an Uncertain Border Region – July 27, 2017



● LAF Protected Border Observation Posts (PBOP) with Towers/ISR

■ LAF Forward Operating Base (FOB)

▲ LAF Checkpoint

■ Areas Controlled by the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria (ISIS)

■ Areas Controlled by Jabhat al-Nusra (JAN)

■ Areas Controlled by Hezbollah

■ Select Displaced Syrian Population

Note: Areas marked in red are areas contested by Syria. Red hexagons are LAF planned PBOP sites currently in the control areas of ISIS or JAN. "MIB" stands for Mechanized Infantry Brigade. "IR" stands for Intervention Regiment

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